ROLEEDGE · CAREER

Salary Negotiation Script Pack

Scripts and Exercises for Every Stage of the Offer Conversation

14	12	Print
SECTIONS	EXERCISES	WITH SPACE TO WRITE

> **How to use this guide:** print it, work through it in order, and write in the spaces. Every exercise has room for your answers, and you can print extra copies of any page.

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From **RoleEdge**, founded by Mayank Kapoor, former Manager at Bain & Company and Warwick MBA. Free to use and share.

Before you start

Welcome to the **Salary Negotiation Script Pack**, your step-by-step guide to transforming how you handle one of the most critical moments in your career: **discussing compensation**. Many professionals undersell themselves, not because they lack talent, but because they don't know the rules of the game.

This pack is designed to change that. Inside, you'll find:

- **Scripts** for each stage of the conversation, ready to adapt.
- **Practical exercises** to adapt the scripts to your situation.
- **Insider psychology** from recruiters and hiring managers.
- **A worked example** of a negotiation from first offer to final number.

Think of it as your **negotiation playbook**. Whether you're a fresher stepping into your first role, a mid-career professional moving industries, or a senior leader switching firms, the ability to negotiate effectively can **change your lifetime earnings trajectory**.

By the end of this pack, you won't just have "lines to say." You'll have the **mindset, confidence, and strategies** to walk into any negotiation with clarity and control.

Read it slowly. Pause for the exercises. Rehearse the scripts. This isn't theory—it's your financial future.

Why Salary Negotiation Matters

Salary negotiation is not about greed—it's about **fairness and recognition**. Imagine two graduates joining the same firm. One accepts the initial offer of ₹14 LPA. The other negotiates and lands ₹16 LPA. At first, the difference looks small—just ₹2 lakhs. But here's the trick: future increments, bonuses, and promotions are calculated as a **percentage of base salary**. Fast forward 10 years. That ₹2 lakh difference compounds into **₹25–30 lakhs more earned** by the negotiator.

Across a 30–40 year career, the lifetime gap can be **₹2–3 crores ($250,000–500,000+ in the West)**. That's the cost of staying silent.

So why do most candidates skip negotiating? Fear. They worry about losing the offer or being seen as "difficult." In reality, recruiters expect negotiation. Many companies **leave room in the budget** because they expect candidates to ask. If you don't, you've left money on the table.

Negotiation is not about confrontation. It's about **presenting evidence of your value** and aligning it with company budgets. Think of it as storytelling: "Here's what I bring, here's what others in the market get, and here's why aligning here makes sense for both of us."

EXERCISE

Write down the last offer you received. Now imagine negotiating 10% higher. Multiply that by 10 years. What's the difference? That's your "negotiation tax" if you stay silent.

	Amount
My last offer	
10% higher	
The difference over 10 years	

The Anatomy of a Great Negotiation

Negotiation isn't random—it's structured. Think of it as a play with four acts:

- **Gratitude** – Always begin by expressing appreciation. "Thank you for the offer. I'm genuinely excited about the opportunity." Gratitude sets a collaborative tone instead of conflict.
- **Value Reinforcement** – Remind them why you're worth more. Mention specific achievements, certifications, or leadership experience that adds measurable business impact.
- **Counter Request** – Clearly state your expectations, preferably as a **range**. Example: "Based on my skills and market benchmarks, I believe ₹18–20 LPA would be a fair range."
- **Collaboration** – End with a willingness to find common ground. "I'm confident we can arrive at a number that works for both of us."

Timing is also key. Don't negotiate until **after the offer is in writing**. Once you see a formal number, you know they want you—that's when your leverage is strongest.

Tone matters as much as words. Sound calm, professional, and confident. Avoid nervous laughter, over-apologizing, or phrases like "if it's not too much to ask." Those weaken your position.

EXERCISE

Write down your next negotiation flow in 4 steps: Gratitude → Value → Counter → Collaboration. Rehearse it until it feels natural.

Step	What I'll say
Gratitude	
Value	
Counter	
Collaboration	

SCRIPT 1

Initial Recruiter Call

This is usually the trickiest moment. You've barely built rapport, and suddenly the recruiter asks: "What are your salary expectations?" Say too low—you anchor yourself down. Say too high—you risk disqualification.

The goal here is **deflection + anchoring**. You don't want to give a single number, but you also don't want to seem clueless.

SAMPLE SCRIPT 1

Recruiter "What are your salary expectations?"

You "Based on my research and industry benchmarks, I'd expect something in the **₹18–20 LPA range**. That said, I'm flexible and more focused on the role's responsibilities and long-term growth."

Why this works:

- **Signals research** – you know your market value.
- **Sets a higher anchor** – recruiter now frames discussions around your range.
- **Keeps flexibility** – shows you're not rigid.

EXERCISE

Write down your own researched salary range for your target role. Then practice saying it out loud until you sound confident—not hesitant.

SCRIPT 2

Handling a Lowball Offer

It happens often. The company comes back with a surprisingly low number. The instinct? Panic or frustration. The smarter move? **Re-anchor calmly.**

SAMPLE SCRIPT 2

Recruiter	"We're offering ₹14 LPA."
You	"Thank you for the offer, I'm very excited about the role. Based on my experience in [X project] and the market benchmarks for similar roles, I was expecting something closer to ₹18–19 LPA. Is there room for us to explore that?"

Why this works:

- Opens with gratitude → keeps tone positive.
- Adds **evidence** (your achievements + market data).
- Uses a question instead of a demand → encourages dialogue.

Most recruiters will test you with a lowball. If you accept immediately, they save money. If you counter respectfully, they often have room to adjust.

EXERCISE

Research the lowest acceptable salary you'd consider. Write it down. This is your walk-away point. Anything below = not worth it.

SCRIPT 3

Counter-Offer Response

When they improve the offer, you've made progress. But don't stop too soon. If you still see room, **push gently for final alignment**.

SAMPLE SCRIPT 3

Recruiter "We revised the offer to ₹16 LPA."

You "I really appreciate the revision—it shows you value my fit for this role. Considering my peers in similar positions earn around ₹18–20 LPA, and the leadership skills I bring, would it be possible to align closer to ₹18 LPA?"

Why this works:

- Acknowledges their move (keeps goodwill).
- Adds **market comparison**.
- Frames your counter as **reasonable, not greedy**.

Many candidates stop negotiating after the first bump. But the real money is often in the **second ask**.

EXERCISE

Write your own polite counter for a scenario where you want ₹2–3 lakhs more. Practice with a friend.

SCRIPT 4

Leveraging Competing Offers

If you're interviewing at multiple places, you hold power. But you must use it carefully. Don't brag or sound threatening. Instead, frame it as **transparency and long-term intent**.

SAMPLE SCRIPT 4

You "I want to be transparent—I'm in final discussions with another firm at around ₹19 LPA. That said, I see a stronger long-term future here. If we could align closer to that, I'd be thrilled to commit."

Why this works:

- Signals **market validation** of your value.
- Shows loyalty → "I prefer you, but align with me."
- Creates urgency for them to match quickly.

GOLDEN RULE

Only use this script if you **truly have another offer**. Recruiters sometimes verify.

EXERCISE

Draft a sentence that frames your competing offer respectfully, without arrogance.

SCRIPT 5

Negotiating Non-Salary Benefits

Sometimes companies hit a hard cap on base salary. That doesn't mean the negotiation is over. **Total compensation** includes perks, bonuses, and benefits.

Options to negotiate:

- Joining bonus.
- Performance bonus.
- Relocation allowance.
- Extra vacation days.
- Flexible work-from-home policy.
- Training budgets or certifications.

SAMPLE SCRIPT 5

You "I understand the constraints on base salary. Could we explore flexibility with a **joining bonus** or **remote work benefits** to balance the package?"

Why this works:

- Shows flexibility.
- Still increases **overall value**.
- Keeps goodwill intact.

EXERCISE

Make a list of 3 non-salary benefits that matter most to you.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Psychology Behind Recruiter Tactics

Recruiters are professionals at saving money. Their tactics are predictable:

- **Anchoring:** Throw a low range to set expectations. Your job? Re-anchor higher.
- **Urgency:** "We need an answer by tomorrow." → Always ask for more time.
- **Silence:** They stay quiet after you counter. Most candidates panic and talk themselves down. Stay calm.

These aren't "tricks"—they're negotiation strategies. Once you see them, you can manage them.

EXERCISE

Recall a time you faced silence or urgency. How did you react? How would you handle it differently now?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Cultural Differences in Negotiation

Negotiation varies globally:

- **India:** Most candidates avoid negotiating. Those who do, win big.
- **US:** Negotiation is expected. Going in without negotiating is seen as a lack of confidence.
- **UK/EU:** Subtle, polite framing works best. Aggressive asks can backfire.
- **Middle East/Asia:** Packages often include housing, travel, and allowances. Negotiate total lifestyle, not just salary.

EXERCISE

Write a script tailored for the country where you're applying.

EXAMPLE

From ₹15 LPA to ₹20 LPA

An illustrative example. Names and details are representative, not real clients.

Candidate: Mid-level consultant.

Initial Offer: ₹15 LPA.

Strategy: Used **market benchmarks + competitor offer + polite counter script**.

Final Offer: ₹20 LPA (+33%).

LESSONS

- She didn't accept the first bump.
- She used **scripts + confidence** to secure 2 revisions.
- Recruiter respected her professionalism.

EXERCISE

Identify a past job where you could have negotiated more. Rewrite that scenario using today's scripts.

Do's & Don'ts Checklist

Do's

- [ ] Research benchmarks (Glassdoor, AmbitionBox, Levels.fyi).
- [ ] Express gratitude before asking.
- [ ] Negotiate total package, not just salary.

Don'ts

- ✕ Don't apologize for negotiating.
- ✕ Don't give your current CTC as your "value."
- ✕ Don't accept instantly—always take 24 hours.

EXERCISE

Circle the top 3 "Do's" you'll apply in your next negotiation.

Action Plan Worksheet

Fill this in before any negotiation.

MY TARGET RANGE

MY WALK-AWAY NUMBER

MARKET BENCHMARK SOURCES

TOP 3 VALUE POINTS I OFFER

THE SCRIPT I'LL USE

MY BATNA (BACKUP PLAN)

Final Review

Before any negotiation:

- [ ] Rehearse your script aloud at least 3 times.
- [ ] Have your “walk-away” number written.
- [ ] Pause, breathe, and remember: **they chose YOU.**

The difference between a ₹15 LPA and ₹20 LPA offer is not luck—it’s preparation.

My notes

NEXT STEP

Want someone to check your work?

Bring this guide to a free call with RoleEdge. We'll go through your answers and help you plan what comes next.

Book a free call at roleedge.com/book